

RESEARCH STATEMENT

Stakeholder Management Competency Differences Between Junior and Senior Business Analysts: Evidence from Industry Professionals in Vietnam

1. Context and Rationale

Business Analysts (BAs) occupy a critical bridging role in Vietnamese IT companies, translating business needs into technical requirements and managing relationships across stakeholder groups that often span different departments, hierarchies, and cultural backgrounds. As Vietnam's software industry grows — now ranked among Southeast Asia's leading outsourcing destinations — demand for BAs capable of handling complex, multi-party stakeholder environments has intensified. Yet industry practitioners and hiring managers consistently report a pronounced readiness gap: junior BAs, despite possessing adequate technical and documentation skills, struggle to perform senior-level stakeholder management tasks independently until well into their second or third year of employment.

Stakeholder management in the BA context encompasses a cluster of interpersonal and organisational competencies that go beyond communication — including conflict resolution, expectation setting, navigating organisational politics, and exerting influence without formal authority. These competencies are difficult to teach in the classroom and are widely understood to develop primarily through sustained, high-stakes project exposure. However, no empirical study has systematically measured this gap in the Vietnamese IT industry, identified which specific sub-competencies diverge most sharply across experience levels, or explored how practitioners themselves explain the development of these capabilities.

This study addresses that practical and empirical gap by directly comparing the self-reported stakeholder management competency profiles of junior BAs (0–2 years of experience) and senior BAs (5+ years of experience) working in Vietnamese IT companies, and by supplementing the quantitative gap profile with qualitative insight from semi-structured interviews.

2. Research Problem Statement

When junior and senior BAs operate within the same project environment, their divergent approaches to stakeholder management can produce inconsistent outcomes: misaligned expectations, unresolved conflicts, and requirements that fail to reflect true business priorities. This inconsistency is not merely a skills deficit — it reflects a developmental gap that compounds across two primary dimensions:

The nature of the competency sub-skill: Some stakeholder management sub-competencies — such as communication clarity and structured expectation setting — may be partially addressed through

formal training, while others — such as influence without authority and organisational political navigation — appear to require direct, contextualised experience to develop.

The organisational context of development: The pace and depth of stakeholder management development may vary significantly depending on company type (product vs. outsourcing vs. consulting), team structure, mentoring availability, and the complexity of client or stakeholder environments encountered early in a BA's career.

Failure to understand this gap with empirical precision carries real costs: organisations cannot target mentoring and training investment efficiently; junior BAs cannot self-diagnose their developmental priorities; and professional training providers lack locally grounded evidence to inform programme design. This study generates the evidence needed to address all three.

3. PICO Framework

The research questions are structured using the PICO framework to ensure clarity, measurability, and answerability:

Element	Description
P – Population	Business Analysts currently employed in Vietnamese IT companies — comprising two groups: junior BAs (0–2 years of professional BA experience) and senior BAs (5 or more years of professional BA experience), drawn from product companies, outsourcing firms, and consulting organisations across Vietnam.
I – Intervention	Self-reported stakeholder management competency, assessed across five sub-dimensions: communication clarity, conflict resolution, expectation management, influence without authority, and organisational political navigation, using a 25-item Likert-scale instrument.
C – Comparison	(1) Comparison of competency scores between junior BAs and senior BAs across the overall scale. (2) Comparison of sub-competency gap magnitude across the five sub-dimensions to identify which skills diverge most and least by experience level. Reference thresholds: Mann-Whitney U $p < 0.05$; rank-biserial $r \geq 0.3$ considered a meaningful effect.

Element	Description
O – Outcome	Overall competency gap profile between experience groups; identification of sub-competencies with the largest and smallest gaps; qualitative themes explaining how practitioners attribute their stakeholder management development; actionable recommendations for BA professional training and mentoring in Vietnamese IT companies. conclusions on the effect of judge type on evaluation consistency; actionable recommendations for rubric refinement and grading process optimization.

4. Research Statement

This study investigates the stakeholder management competency gap between junior BAs (0–2 years of experience) and senior BAs (5+ years of experience) employed in the Vietnamese IT industry, using a validated 25-item self-report instrument covering five sub-competencies: communication clarity, conflict resolution, expectation management, influence without authority, and organisational political navigation. The research examines whether the two experience groups differ significantly in overall and sub-competency scores, which sub-competencies show the largest and smallest gaps, and how practitioners qualitatively account for the development of their stakeholder management capabilities. Findings are expected to provide the first empirical competency gap profile for BAs in Vietnam and to offer actionable recommendations for professional development programme design, mentoring scheme structure, and BA career pathway planning in Vietnamese IT companies.

5. Main and Sub-Research Questions

5.1 Main Research Question

"To what extent do junior and senior Business Analysts working in the Vietnamese IT industry differ in stakeholder management competencies, which specific sub-skills exhibit the largest gaps, and how do practitioners themselves explain their competency development?"

5.2 Sub-Research Questions

Sub-RQ	Research Question	Measurement Methodology
RQ1	Do junior BAs and senior BAs differ significantly in overall stakeholder management competency scores?	Mann-Whitney U test; rank-biserial effect size r ; descriptive statistics (median, IQR, mean, SD)

Sub-RQ	Research Question	Measurement Methodology
RQ2	Which scoring criteria show the highest and lowest inter-rater agreement — Technical criteria vs. Soft/subjective criteria?	Per-criterion ICC & α ; ranking comparison
RQ3	How do junior and senior BAs qualitatively describe their stakeholder management approaches, and what factors do they attribute to their competency development?	Reflexive thematic analysis of semi-structured interview transcripts (8–12 participants)

6. Research Significance

6.1 Theoretical Contribution

- Provides the first empirical stakeholder management competency gap profile for BAs in the Vietnamese IT industry, contributing to the regional software engineering and professional development literature.
- Tests practitioner-based claims about which stakeholder management competencies are most experience-dependent, using locally grounded data rather than imported Western norms.
- Extends the mixed-methods competency research tradition by combining validated quantitative measurement with practitioner narrative, generating both a gap profile and an explanatory model of BA development in Southeast Asia.

6.2 Practical Contribution

- Delivers an empirical sub-competency gap report to HR and L&D teams at participating Vietnamese IT companies, identifying which stakeholder management skills require the most targeted development investment for junior BAs.
- Provides evidence-based recommendations for mentoring programme structure, onboarding curriculum content, and BA career pathway design in Vietnamese IT organisations.
- Produces a validated 25-item stakeholder management competency instrument suitable for ongoing HR benchmarking and practitioner self-assessment, replicable in future cohorts and comparable across companies.
- Disseminates findings through the BA Vietnam professional community and domestic IT conferences, maximising reach and practical uptake beyond the immediate research team.

7. Scope and Limitations

- The scope is strictly confined to Business Analysts, Systems Analysts, and Product Owners currently employed in Vietnamese IT companies; findings will not be extended to other countries or non-IT industries during this research phase.

- The study uses newly collected survey and self-report interview data; archival performance records, project outcomes, or third-party competency assessments are outside scope.
- Experience classification relies on self-reported years of BA experience as a proxy for junior/senior designation; mid-level BAs (3–4 years) are excluded from primary comparisons to maximise group contrast.
- The quantitative phase measures perceived (self-reported) competency, not observed performance; results are interpreted accordingly and this limitation is explicitly stated in the Discussion section.
- The qualitative phase involves 8–12 interviews and produces illustrative, hypothesis-generating findings rather than statistically generalisable conclusions.
- The research is a cross-sectional observational study; no longitudinal tracking of competency development over time is conducted within this study.